> immense role in the education of Bhagat Singh, of equal if not greater significance is the literary and aesthetic space that allowed him to cast himself as part of an international brotherhood formed around the gallows. This is brought home most powerfully by references to the Russian novella, *The Seven Who Were Hanged* (1908) in the reminiscences of two of Bhagat Singh's co-prisoners in Lahore Central Jail, Shiv Verma and Jatinder Nath Sanyal. Referring to Bhagat Singh's interest in Dickens, Upton Sinclair, Hall Caine, Victor Hugo, Oscar Wilde, Gorky, Stepniak and in particular Leonid Andreyev, Shiv Verma recounts:
>
> 'He frequently got emotionally involved with some particular characters in the novels, to the extent that he wept and laughed with them. A familiar instance was a character in Leonard Andrew's [*sic*] novel *The Seven Who Were Hanged*. This character kept on saying, "I shall not be hanged." While he was being actually led to the gallows, he was still saying, "I shall not be hanged." Upon reading this, Bhagat Singh would first laugh heartily, and then be silent and tears would start dropping from his eyes.'[2]

Simona Sawhney asks, 'What could Bhagat Singh's laughter and tears signify? We can only speculate.' She adds that surely the tears are 'a moment of identification' leading to the conclusion that 'the revolutionary does not love death because he hates life. On the contrary, it is precisely love of life that also demands love of death so that both life and death may be wrestled away from totalitarian control'. For Sawhney, 'Bhagat Singh's encounter with this novel should be read along with all the moments in his writings where he either glorifies the death of heroes, or argues against suicide (in a famous letter to Sukhdev), or gestures, through citation or allusion, towards a sweet intimacy with death'. Given his quest of overcoming the fear of death and suffering, Sawhney explains, 'The many references to the importance of enduring suffering, the prolonged practice of the hunger strike, and the defiant gesture of laughing at the moment of execution are all part of this challenge.'[3] Indeed, Sawhney goes further and even recognizes that in this sense there are in Bhagat Singh's work 'arguments similar to those made by Frantz Fanon: that at a systemic level the violence can only be confronted by the violence of the colonized, and at an individual level, violence functions as a way of restoring agency and capacity to a humiliated people'.[4]

It is this restoration of agency and capacity to a humiliated people that also accounts for Bhagat Singh's writing of his most controversial piece